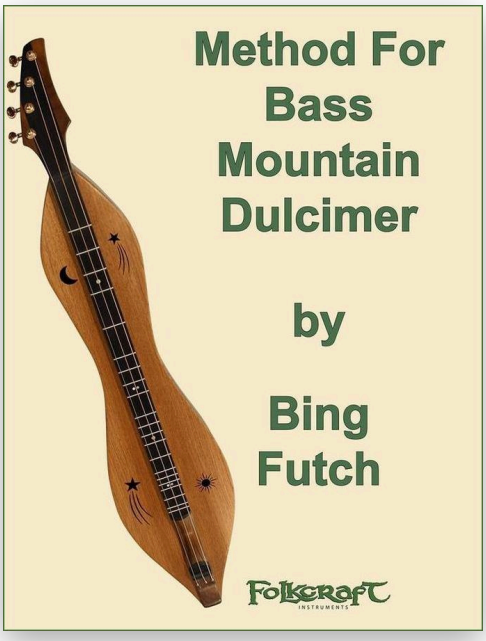
FINGERS OF STEEL® PUBLICATIONS

Method For Bass Mountain Dulcimer

by Bing Futch

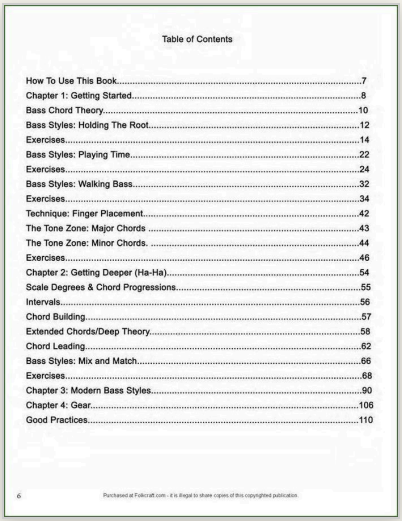


Bing Futch's Method For Bass Mountain Dulcimer is a complete instruction book for players adding the bass mountain dulcimer to their music. It starts with just enough theory to get you playing and goes on to embellishments and rhythmic variations.

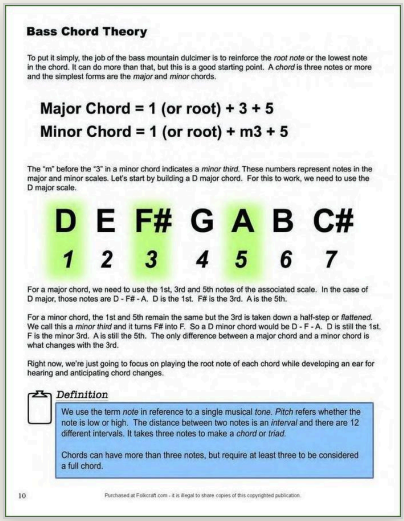
The bass mountain dulcimer is typically tuned DAD, like a standard dulcimer but a full octave lower, and it fills a unique niche in solo and ensemble playing. With this book you'll learn to:

Free demo audio

INSIDE THE BOOK


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Bass Chord Theory

To put it simply, the job of the bass mountain dulcimer is to reinforce the *root note* or the lowest note in the chord. It can do more than that, but this is a good starting point. A *chord* is three notes or more and the simplest forms are the *major* and *minor* chords.

Major Chord = 1 (or root) + 3 + 5
Minor Chord = 1 (or root) + m3 + 5

The "m" before the "3" in a minor chord indicates a *minor third*. These numbers represent notes in the major and minor scales. Let's start by building a D major chord. For this to work, we need to use the D major scale.

D	E	F#	G	A	B	C#
1	2	3	4	5	6	7

For a major chord, we need to use the 1st, 3rd and 5th notes of the associated scale. In the case of D major, those notes are D - F# - A. D is the 1st. F# is the 3rd. A is the 5th.
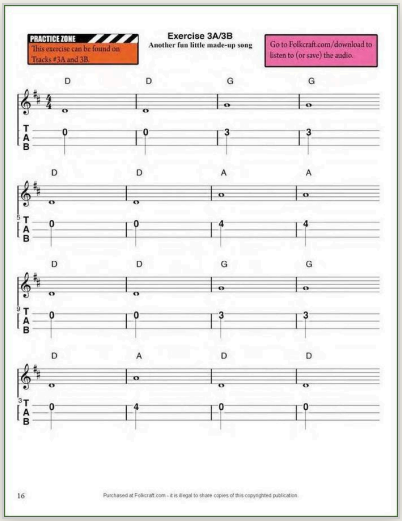
For a minor chord, the 1st and 5th remain the same but the 3rd is taken down a half-step or *flattened*. We call this a *minor third* and it turns F# into F. So a D minor chord would be D - F - A. D is still the 1st. F is the minor 3rd. A is still the 5th. The only difference between a major chord and a minor chord is what changes with the 3rd.

Right now, we're just going to focus on playing the root note of each chord while developing an ear for hearing and anticipating chord changes.

Definition

We use the term *note* in reference to a single musical *tone*. *Pitch* refers whether the note is low or high. The distance between two notes is an *interval* and there are 12 different intervals. It takes three notes to make a *chord* or *triad*.

Chords can have more than three notes, but require at least three to be considered a full chord.


PRACTICE ZONE
This exercise can be found on Tracks 4A and 4B.

Exercise 3A/3B
Another fun little made-up song

Go to Folkcraft.com/download to listen to (or save) the audio.

D D G G
T 0 0 3 3
A
B

D D A A
T 0 0 4 4
A
B

D D G G
T 0 0 3 3
A
B

D A D D
T 0 4 0 0
A
B

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